

# “Is this AI?” is the wrong question.

The one that actually decides your validation  
burden — and the four answers that settle it.

# Ask “is this AI?” and you get a **definitional debate.**

Almost anything can be argued into or out of the label. And nothing about the answer tells you what validation you owe.

# The question that works: “What happens when it’s wrong?”

Regulators reason about consequence, not category. Your intake form should too.

QUESTION 01

# What does the output touch?

A GxP decision, a GxP record, or neither. If it touches neither, you're documenting scope — not validating a system.

Scope, before anything else

QUESTION 02

# How much does it influence that decision?

Informational. Advisory. Direct. Autonomous. Influence is a dial — and it moves your obligation far more than the technology does.

FDA: influence × consequence

QUESTION 03

# Can it change on its own?

A locked model behaves tomorrow the way it behaved at qualification. An adaptive one — or a vendor-updated one — does not. That single difference is your entire monitoring burden.

Locked vs adaptive

QUESTION 04

# What does the human actually do?

Reviews every output, samples them, or rubber-stamps them. “Human in the loop” isn’t a control until you can say which — and show it works.

Automation bias is real



# Four answers. One repeatable decision.

- Same inputs, same class — whoever runs the form.
- Proportionate depth — most low-risk uses clear in days, not quarters.
- A defensible record — the reasoning survives “why this level?”
- A re-trigger — re-run it when the model, the use, or the vendor changes.



# Governance isn't the brake. Not being able to decide is.

If your AI projects are waiting on a framework, the bottleneck isn't risk appetite. It's the absence of a repeatable answer.

# Has your org started the AI-in-GxP journey?

Forward this to your QA, CSV or IT lead — it's the conversation they're about to be in.

And if something here doesn't fit your setup, ask me. Happy to answer anything on this.

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